Why Similar States Diverge: Identity, Mobilization, and Political Competition in Georgia and Louisiana

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Abstract

This thesis examines the political divergence between Georgia and Louisiana, two Southern states with nearly identical historical foundations that have arrived at fundamentally different political destinations. Georgia has emerged as one of the most competitive electoral battlegrounds in the United States, while Louisiana remains among the most politically static. Drawing on Arlie Russell Hochschild's framework of the "deep story," Larry Bartels' theory of unequal democracy, and Michael Dawson's Black utility heuristic, this thesis argues that the divergence cannot be explained by demographics alone. Instead, it is the product of three compounding structural differences: the architecture of political identity, the scale and durability of civic mobilization, and the responsiveness of political institutions. Using a Most Similar Systems Design with Mississippi as a control case, this study demonstrates that Georgia's rigid Black-White binary, permanent civic infrastructure, and diversified creative economy created a self-reinforcing feedback loop of electoral competition. Louisiana's tripartite Creole identity structure, patronage-based mobilization, and extractive petro-state economy produced the opposite — a self-reinforcing loop of institutional stasis. The findings suggest that demographic presence is a prerequisite for political change, not a guarantee of it, and that the design of institutions determines whether the demand of a changing population can ever reach the levers of power.

Table of Contents

I. Introduction **4**
1.1 The Problem of Divergence 4
1.2 Why Existing Explanations Fall Short 5
1.3 The Argument in Brief 6
1.4 Theoretical Framework: Identity, Inequality, Mobilization, and Institutional Supply 7
1.5 Literature Review: Southern Politics and the Theory of Realignment 10
1.6 Methodology and Case Selection 11
1.7 Theoretical Scope and the Limits of Comparative Consistency 12
II. Identity Formation **12**
2.1 Religious Identity and Political Culture 13
2.2 Racial Identity Structures 14
2.3 Impact on Political Behavior 16
2.4 The Identity Trap: Why Demographics are not Destiny 17
III. Patterns of Mobilization and Civic Infrastructure **18**
3.1 The “Stacey Abrams” Model: Organizing as Permanent Infrastructure 19
3.2 The 2025 Dissolution: Infrastructure as a War of Attrition 21
3.3 The Black Church: From the Pulpit to the Polls 22
3.4 HBCUs Political Incubators 23
3.5 Louisiana: The Persistence of Patronage and Machine Politics 24
3.5.1 The "Brokerage" Bottleneck: Why Machines Fail to Scale 26
3.6 Case Study: “Souls to the Polls” vs. The Parish Machine 27
3.7 The Digital Ground Game: Tech Hubs vs. the Digital Divide 28
3.7.1 The Political Consequences of the Digital Divide 29
3.8 Linked Fate and the Utility of the Vote: A Dawsonian Analysis 29
3.8.1 The Fractured "Linked Fate" of the Gulf South 30
IV. Political Power Structures and Institutional Evolution **30**
4.1 Georgia: The Collapse of Rural Dominance and the Suburban Handover 31
4.1.1 The Rise of "Business Republicanism" and the Creative Economy 32
4.1.2 Case Study: The Suburban Realignment of Gwinnett County 33
4.1.3 Re-Writing the Deep Story: Gwinnett County as a Laboratory 33
4.2 Louisiana: The "Petro-State" and Institutional Inertia 34
4.2.1 The Economic Hegemony of "The Company" and the LOGA Lobby 34
4.2.2 Case Study: The "Jungle Primary" and the Stifling of Partisan Infrastructure 35
4.2.3 The Closed Primary Transition: A Different Tool for the Same Stasis 36
4.2.4 The Fragmented Core: Why New Orleans is not Atlanta 37
4.3 Consequences: Fluidity vs. Stasis 37
4.3.1 The Mechanical Result of Fluidity in Georgia 37
4.3.2 The Mechanical Result of Stasis in Louisiana 38
4.4 The Judicial Veto: Redistricting and the Battle for "Supply" 39
4.4.1 Synthesis: Why the Paths Diverged 39
4.5 The Material Basis of Stasis: Revenue Streams and Elite Autonomy 40
V. Divergence Over Time **41**

5.1 The Early Divergence: Small Differences, Large Consequences 41
5.2 The Acceleration Period: 2008–2020 42
Table 1. Presidential Election Margins in Georgia and Louisiana, 2008–2024 43
5.3 Synthesis: The Long-Term Interaction of Demand and Supply 44
5.3.1 The Divergent Costs of Information and Participation 45
5.4 The Feedback Loop of National Investment: Bartels and the "Supply" of Competition 45
VI. Conclusion: Two Souths, Three Paths, and the Future of Democracy 46
6.1 Synthesizing the Pillars of Divergence 47
6.2 The Mississippi Control Case: The Legal Moat of the Old South 48
6.2.1 The "Closed Loop" of Institutional Entrenchment 48
6.3 Broader Implications: The "Two Souths" Thesis 49
6.4 Paths for Further Research 50
6.5 Final Reflections 50
References 51

I. Introduction

1.1 The Problem of Divergence

The American South is often treated as a monolith. In popular political commentary, it is described as a region defined by its past — by racial hierarchy, religious conservatism, and resistance to federal power. Yet this characterization has become increasingly difficult to sustain. The modern South is not a single political entity. It is a region fracturing along fault lines of identity, economy, and institutional design. The divergence between Georgia and Louisiana represents the clearest expression of this fracture. These two states share nearly identical historical foundations, yet their political destinies have moved in opposite directions. Georgia is now one of the most consequential swing states in the country. Louisiana is one of the most static. That contrast demands explanation.

The political landscape of the American South is no longer uniform. While some states remain deeply conservative, others have undergone rapid political transformation. Among the clearest examples of this divergence are Louisiana and Georgia, two states rooted in parallel histories of racial hierarchy, religious conservatism, and economic instability. Yet their contemporary politics have moved in opposite directions. Georgia has become increasingly competitive, shaping national elections and emerging as a key battleground for both major parties, while Louisiana remains politically static. Understanding how this divergence emerged—and what it reveals about the forces that make electorates shift or remain frozen—is the central puzzle of this thesis. Although political change in America is often described through economic explanations, the contrast between Louisiana and Georgia suggests a different story shaped by identity, power, and mobilization.

1.2 Why Existing Explanations Fall Short

The most common explanations for political change in the American South — economic shifts, demographic growth, and partisan realignment — are insufficient on their own. Economic models predict that declining material conditions should produce pressure for redistributive political change. Yet Louisiana, which consistently ranks among the poorest states in the nation, has not produced a sustained challenge to its conservative power structure. Demographic models predict that population growth among minority voters should produce partisan competitiveness over time. Yet Georgia and Louisiana have nearly identical racial compositions, and only one has become competitive. Partisan realignment theories suggest that national political tides should reshape Southern states uniformly. Yet these two states have responded to the same national environment in fundamentally different ways. The failure of these frameworks to explain the divergence is not a flaw in the theories themselves. It is a signal that something more specific — more structural — is at work.

This thesis argues that the political divergence between Georgia and Louisiana is best explained by differences in identity formation, patterns of mobilization, and the strength of political power structures. Although these states share similar racial, cultural, and economic foundations, their political trajectories reveal how small variations in demographic change, organizational capacity, and elite influence can compound over time. Comparing these cases helps illuminate why some electorates evolve while others remain effectively unchanged for decades.

1.3 The Argument in Brief

This thesis argues that the divergence between Georgia and Louisiana is the product of three compounding structural differences: the architecture of political identity, the scale and durability of civic mobilization, and the responsiveness of political institutions. None of these factors operate in isolation. Identity shapes the demand for political change. Mobilization converts that demand into organized pressure. And institutions determine whether that pressure can reach the levers of power. Where these

three forces aligned — as they did in Georgia — the result was a transformative feedback loop of increasing electoral competition. Where they diverged — as they did in Louisiana — the result was a self-reinforcing loop of stasis. Understanding how this happened requires moving beyond the surface-level demographics and into the structural machinery that connects voters to power.

Both states were founded during eras of exploration and territorial expansion. Louisiana—claimed by the French in 1682, settled at Fort St. Jean Baptiste in 1714, and incorporated into the United States in 1803 through the Louisiana Purchase—became a state in 1812. Georgia, founded in 1732 by the British in Savannah as the last of the original thirteen colonies, developed along a similar timeline. Each relied heavily on plantation economies rooted in labor-intensive cash crops such as cotton, sugar, and tobacco, creating a deeply entrenched racial hierarchy between enslaved Africans and white landowners—a hierarchy that would shape their politics well into the modern era.

Religion also played a pivotal but distinct role in each state's development. Georgia was shaped primarily by white evangelical Protestantism, a tradition closely associated with conservatism, racial hierarchy, and Republican political identity. Louisiana, by contrast, emerged as one of the most strongly Catholic regions in the United States due to French and Spanish colonization. Yet even Louisiana's Catholicism operated within the broader southern framework, reinforcing traditional social values, hierarchical community structures, and resistance to rapid political change. In both states, religion stabilized political behavior and sustained one-party dominance for much of the twentieth century, creating the expectation that their political structures would evolve similarly over time.

For most of the twentieth century, these expectations held. Both states functioned as one-party Democratic strongholds built on Jim Crow institutions, racial exclusion, and limited political competition. Elections were shaped more by intraparty factionalism than partisan conflict. Even the partisan realignment following the civil rights movement pushed both states toward the Republican Party at roughly the same time, reinforcing the assumption that their political futures would continue to move in

tandem. Yet beginning in the early twenty-first century, their paths diverged sharply: Georgia steadily transitioned from a reliably conservative state to a site of growing electoral competition, while Louisiana became increasingly static and overwhelmingly Republican.

The challenge, then, is to understand how two states that began and developed so similarly could diverge so dramatically in their political futures. The remainder of this thesis proceeds in three parts: first, an examination of how identity formation diverged in each state; second, an analysis of the evolution of mobilization networks; and third, an assessment of how political elites and institutions reinforced or reshaped each trajectory.

1.4 Theoretical Framework: Identity, Inequality, Mobilization, and Institutional Supply

Political scientists have long debated the mechanisms that cause electorates to shift over time while others remain remarkably stable. Traditional explanations for electoral behavior typically fall into three broad categories: economic voting, demographic change, and identity-based alignment. Economic models assume that voters respond rationally to material conditions by rewarding or punishing parties based on fiscal performance. Demographic approaches emphasize population shifts, such as migration and aging, as the primary drivers of partisan transformation. Identity-based theories highlight the central role of race, religion, and culture in structuring political preferences. While each framework captures important elements of political behavior, none alone sufficiently explains cases in which states with comparable foundations experience divergent trajectories. Georgia and Louisiana present a significant puzzle in this regard. Both share similar racial compositions, histories of racial exclusion, deep economic inequality, and regional political cultures. Yet, in the twenty-first century, Georgia has become electorally competitive while Louisiana remains politically static. This divergence suggests that political change cannot be explained solely by demographic presence or economic hardship. Instead, political transformation depends on the specific interaction between identity, inequality, mobilization, and institutional responsiveness.

Identity-based theories of political behavior emphasize that voters do not interpret political and economic conditions through purely material calculations. Instead, perceptions of fairness, belonging, and status shape political meaning. In *Strangers in Their Own Land*, Arlie Russell Hochschild (2016) introduces the concept of a "deep story," which functions as a moral narrative through which individuals make sense of social and cultural change. These narratives provide emotionally resonant interpretations of inequality, government intervention, and social hierarchy. Hochschild demonstrates that economic hardship does not necessarily produce redistributive political preferences. Individuals may experience declining economic conditions yet maintain partisan loyalty if political institutions align with their cultural or moral identities. In such cases, resentment may be directed not at structural inequality but at perceived cultural displacement or government favoritism toward others. Identity thus mediates the translation of economic conditions into political behavior.

When applied to the Georgia–Louisiana comparison, the "deep story" helps explain why persistent inequality in Louisiana has not generated sustained pressure for partisan realignment. Cultural conservatism, religious identity, and long-standing narratives of regional distinctiveness shape how political grievances are interpreted. Political demand is not simply a function of economic deprivation because it is filtered through identity-based moral frameworks.

While identity shapes political perception, institutions determine whether political preferences translate into outcomes. In *Unequal Democracy*, Larry Bartels (2016) argues that American democracy is characterized by unequal responsiveness. The policy preferences of affluent citizens are significantly more likely to be enacted than those of lower-income citizens. When the preferences of lower-income voters conflict with those of wealthier constituencies, the former exert minimal independent influence on policy outcomes. This unequal responsiveness has important consequences for participation. When institutions systematically privilege elite preferences, marginalized groups may disengage because they perceive political participation as ineffective.

Political inequality thus becomes self-reinforcing. Limited influence discourages participation, and low participation further reduces influence. In Louisiana, institutional arrangements, including elite-dominated industries and patronage networks, limit the responsiveness of political institutions to broad-based voter demand. Even where large segments of the electorate share common grievances, institutional barriers can prevent those grievances from reshaping political outcomes. Georgia presents a contrasting case. Although inequality and racial hierarchy remain central features of its history, institutional changes and the growth of competitive suburban constituencies created openings for new coalitions to exert influence. Institutional responsiveness does not imply ideological transformation. Rather, it refers to the capacity of political systems to absorb mobilized participation and translate it into electoral consequences.

Between identity-driven demand and institutional supply lies the variable of mobilization. Demographic presence does not automatically yield political power. Groups must be organized, registered, and sustained through durable civic infrastructure in order to influence institutions. Mobilization lowers the costs of participation and transforms latent grievances into collective action. The Georgia case illustrates how sustained, year-round mobilization infrastructure, rooted in churches, civic organizations, and educational institutions, converted demographic change into political competition. Turnout increases in key metropolitan counties and expanded voter registration reflect the activation of previously underrepresented constituencies. Mobilization thus amplified demand and increased the likelihood that institutions would respond. Louisiana, by contrast, exhibits fragmented mobilization. Civic efforts are often localized and episodic rather than institutionalized and statewide. In the absence of sustained mobilization, identity-based grievances remain politically diffuse, and institutions face limited pressure to adapt.

Political divergence emerges from the interaction between demand and supply. Demand refers to voter preferences, identity-based narratives, and mobilization efforts. Supply refers to institutional responsiveness, party competition, and elite incentives. Electoral transformation requires both factors to

align. Georgia demonstrates the alignment of mobilized demand and institutional supply. Identity-based mobilization coincided with electoral structures capable of translating participation into competitive outcomes. Louisiana illustrates a disjunction. Identity-based narratives exist, but mobilization remains fragmented and institutions remain insulated from broad-based pressure. Political change is not inevitable. It occurs when mobilized voters encounter institutions that are sufficiently responsive to alter power structures. Where institutions are extractive or unresponsive, demographic potential remains politically dormant. By integrating identity theory, political inequality, and mobilization research, this framework moves beyond demographic determinism. It explains why similar states can diverge and demonstrates that electoral outcomes depend not only on who lives in a state, but on how political meaning is constructed and how institutions distribute influence.

1.5 Literature Review: Southern Politics and the Theory of Realignment

To understand why Georgia and Louisiana have diverged, this study must be situated within the broader canon of Southern political science. The foundational text for any comparative study of the region is V.O. Key's (1949) *Southern Politics in State and Nation*. Key argued that the "axis of Southern politics" was the relationship between the "Black Belt" counties—where enslaved labor was most concentrated—and the rest of the state. Key's "Black Threat Hypothesis" suggested that white political behavior was primarily driven by a desire to maintain racial hegemony in areas with high Black populations. While Key's work explains the "Solid South" era, it struggles to account for the twenty-first-century divergence. If racial density were the sole determinant of political behavior, Georgia and Louisiana should still be tracking identically.

This thesis builds on Key's foundation by integrating modern theories of "Suburban Realignment." Scholars such as Kevin Kruse (2005) and Matthew Lassiter (2006) have argued that the true driver of Southern change was not just race, but the "Sunbelt" economic model. Kruse's study of Atlanta's "white flight" demonstrates that suburbanization created a new kind of "colorblind"

conservatism that eventually provided the opening for the multi-ethnic coalitions seen in Georgia today. By contrast, Louisiana's lack of a massive, diversifying suburban ring—comparable to Gwinnett or Cobb counties—prevented this "Suburban Realignment" from occurring at scale.

Furthermore, this study engages with the "Black Utility Heuristic" and the work of Michael Dawson (1994). Dawson argues that Black political behavior is characterized by "linked fate," where individuals perceive their own well-being as tied to the status of the group. In Georgia, this linked fate was successfully channeled through year-round mobilization infrastructure. In Louisiana, however, the "Deep Story" of abandonment (Hochschild, 2016) and the fragmentation of the "Institutional Supply" (Bartels, 2016) have made it more difficult for this sense of linked fate to translate into statewide electoral victories

1.6 Methodology and Case Selection

This thesis utilizes a "Most Similar Systems Design" (MSSD), a comparative method that selects cases similar in as many variables as possible—the "controls"—but differing in the outcome being studied—the "dependent variable". Georgia and Louisiana are ideal for this design because they share foundational Southern "controls": a history of labor-intensive plantation economies, a high percentage of Black residents, and a shared legacy of Jim Crow institutional exclusion.

By controlling for these shared histories, this study isolates the "independent variables" that caused the political divergence. These variables include the structure of religious and racial identity (Protestant vs. Catholic/Creole), the scale of mobilization infrastructure (Year-round vs. Localized/Episodic), and the material basis of the power structure (Creative/Diversified vs. Extractive/Petro-State). Data for this study was compiled from U.S. Census Bureau reports (2024), Secretary of State election returns (2016–2024), and qualitative analysis of the foundational texts by Larry Bartels, Arlie Russell Hochschild, and Michael Dawson.

1.7 Theoretical Scope and the Limits of Comparative Consistency

While the Most Similar Systems Design (MSSD) provides a robust framework for isolating variables in Georgia and Louisiana, it is necessary to acknowledge the inherent limits of this model. Political science often struggles with "context-specificity," and the framework of Identity, Mobilization, and Power Structures may not translate perfectly to other Sunbelt states like Texas or North Carolina. In those cases, the "Identity" variable is further complicated by massive Hispanic population growth and different patterns of migration. By focusing on the Georgia-Louisiana-Mississippi triad, this thesis prioritizes the "Black Belt" historical experience. Acknowledging these boundaries ensures that the findings are not over-generalized, but rather serve as a specific autopsy of the Deep South's internal divergence.

II. Identity Formation

Political identity is not merely demographic; it is historically constructed through religious traditions, racial categorization, and legal frameworks that shape how communities interpret power, authority, and belonging. Although Georgia and Louisiana are both Southern states shaped by slavery and segregation, they emerged from fundamentally different colonial and cultural foundations. These differences in religious identity and racial hierarchy continue to structure political alignment, coalition-building, and partisan behavior.

2.1 Religious Identity and Political Culture

The religious foundations of Georgia and Louisiana diverged from their earliest colonial periods. Georgia developed under British Protestant colonial rule following its 1732 charter. Georgia's political culture evolved within an Anglo-Protestant framework that emphasized evangelical revivalism, individual morality, and congregational authority. Over time, Georgia became deeply embedded within the Evangelical Protestant culture of the "Bible Belt," where Baptist and Methodist denominations shaped both civic life and political discourse. According to the Pew Research Center (2024), approximately 38%

of Georgia's adult population identifies as Evangelical Protestant, with the Southern Baptist Convention representing the largest single denomination in the state.

This Protestant foundation reinforced a moralized political culture that serves as a primary "filter" for political perception. As Hochschild (2016) suggests in her analysis of the "deep story," religious identity provides the moral scaffolding for how individuals interpret their place in the social order. In Georgia, Evangelical networks function not only as religious institutions but as highly disciplined organizational structures capable of statewide mobilization. Issues such as abortion, religious liberty, and traditional family structures became closely intertwined with partisan identity. This alignment contributed to a significant consolidation of white Evangelical voters within the Republican Party, with exit polls frequently showing that over 80% of white Evangelicals in Georgia support Republican candidates (Pew Research Center, 2024). In Georgia, religious identity maps cleanly onto partisan affiliation, which reinforces ideological polarization and creates predictable coalition boundaries.

Louisiana's development followed a markedly different trajectory. The territory was governed first by France and later by Spain before its incorporation into the United States through the Louisiana Purchase in 1803. Consequently, Catholicism became the dominant religious tradition, particularly in the southern parishes shaped by Creole and Cajun heritage. Catholic political culture historically emphasized institutional mediation, communal obligation, and a hierarchical social structure, which differs from the decentralized revivalist tradition characteristic of Protestant Georgia. Today, approximately 26% of Louisiana's population identifies as Catholic, with the highest concentrations found in the Acadiana region (Pew Research Center, 2024).

These divergent religious foundations matter politically because they influence the scale of mobilization. In Georgia, Evangelical networks often operate as coordinated, statewide channels closely aligned with the Republican partisan structure. In Louisiana, Catholic identity is regionally concentrated and culturally influential but is less uniformly tied to a single partisan apparatus. This reflects a "deep

story" in Louisiana that is often mediated through local parish identity rather than a statewide moral crusade. As a result, religious mobilization in Louisiana tends to be localized and less systematically integrated into statewide political competition, contributing to the state's institutional stasis.

2.2 Racial Identity Structures

Racial identity structures further distinguish the two states and determine how political demand is expressed. Georgia developed within an Anglo-American racial order defined by a rigid Black-White binary. Following the Reconstruction era, the consolidation of Jim Crow laws institutionalized strict racial categorization through the "one-drop rule" and legally enforced segregation. This hardened racial boundary produced a polarized political environment in which race became a primary organizing principle of partisan alignment.

The clarity of this racial polarization simplifies coalition-building strategies and facilitates targeted mobilization. According to the U.S. Census Bureau (2024), Georgia's population is approximately 50.1% non-Hispanic white and 33.2% Black. This demographic split, combined with the rigid identity structures, means that mobilization efforts can be deployed with high precision. In Georgia, the "deep story" for many Black voters is one of collective resilience against institutional exclusion, while the narrative for many white conservative voters often focuses on the protection of traditional social hierarchies (Hochschild, 2016).

Louisiana's racial history included a more complex colonial system of classification. Under French and Spanish rule, Louisiana recognized a distinct class of *gens de couleur libres* (free people of color). This created a tripartite social structure that included whites, enslaved Africans, and free Creoles of color. Although Jim Crow laws ultimately imposed rigid segregation across the South, remnants of this layered identity structure persisted in cultural, legal, and social distinctions tied to language and heritage. Louisiana's population is approximately 57.1% non-Hispanic white and 31.4% Black (U.S. Census Bureau, 2024).

This historical layering affects modern political behavior by diffusing statewide partisan consolidation. While Louisiana's Black electorate today remains strongly Democratic, the state's racial politics often intersect with regional identities and parish-level loyalties. As Larry Bartels (2016) notes, when political identities are fragmented, institutions are often less responsive to the needs of the broader public. In Louisiana, the legacy of Creole identity and the geographic split between the "Protestant North" and the "Catholic South" creates a more fractured electorate than the one found in Georgia. This fragmentation allows entrenched elites to maintain power through patronage networks rather than responding to a unified partisan demand.

The critical question is not simply why Louisiana's identity is fragmented, but why that fragmentation has proven so resistant to consolidation over time. In Georgia, the rigid Black-White binary was itself a product of institutional enforcement — the "one-drop rule," legally mandated segregation, and the political machinery of Jim Crow hardened racial categories into durable political ones. When those legal structures collapsed under the weight of the civil rights movement, the binary they had enforced did not disappear. It was absorbed into partisan identity, providing the clean, durable coalition boundaries that mobilizers like Stacey Abrams could later activate. Louisiana's tripartite legacy operated differently. The gens de couleur libres created a middle stratum that was never fully absorbed into either the white political structure or the broader Black political identity. Even as Jim Crow nominally flattened these distinctions, the cultural residue of Creole identity, parish-level loyalty, and regional Catholic-Protestant division persisted beneath the surface of formal racial categorization. These identities were never institutionally resolved into a unified political coalition. They were simply suppressed — and suppressed identities, unlike eliminated ones, tend to resurface as political fragmentation the moment the institutional pressure holding them down is relaxed. This is why Louisiana's identity fragmentation is not a temporary condition waiting to be overcome by the right mobilization strategy. It is a structural feature of the state's political culture, one that must be actively dismantled rather than simply organized around.

2.3 Impact on Political Behavior

The religious and racial identity structures outlined above do not merely reflect cultural variation. They shape the mechanics of political behavior and determine the "institutional supply" of political outcomes. Identity influences how voters interpret policy debates and how parties construct electoral strategies. In both Georgia and Louisiana, identity functions as a filter through which political grievances are processed, but the structure of that filter differs significantly.

In Georgia, the convergence of a rigid Black-White binary and a deeply institutionalized Evangelical Protestant culture produces a highly polarized environment. This polarization generates clear partisan cues. As demographic change expands the proportion of nonwhite and younger voters, the activation of these groups produces measurable electoral consequences. This is because the partisan boundaries are already sharply defined, making it easier for organizations like the New Georgia Project to convert registration into votes. The "demand" for change in Georgia is met by an "institutional supply" that, while often resistant, is forced to respond to the sheer scale of the mobilized, polarized electorate.

Louisiana presents a more layered dynamic where the legacy of Catholic traditions and Creole identity diffuses partisan alignment. This complicates statewide coalition-building. Although Black voters in Louisiana remain strongly Democratic, the state’s political environment is structured less by rigid two-pole polarization and more by localized patronage networks and candidate-centered politics. Identity in Louisiana is intertwined with parish affiliation and personal networks, which can dilute the translation of demographic presence into cohesive partisan demand.

As Bartels (2016) argues, in systems characterized by "unequal democracy," institutions are often more responsive to organized elites than to the preferences of the general public. In Louisiana, the fragmentation of identity-based demand ensures that political elites face less pressure to adapt. Where identity produces clear, durable partisan blocs, as in Georgia, parties have stronger incentives to invest in mobilization infrastructure. Where identity is regionally fragmented and mediated through patronage, as

in Louisiana, elites prioritize maintaining localized influence. This fundamental difference in how identity structures political behavior explains why two states with similar demographics have reached such different political destinations.

2.4 The Identity Trap: Why Demographics are not Destiny

The divergence in identity structures between Georgia and Louisiana reveals a critical flaw in "demographic determinism." It is often assumed that a high percentage of minority voters will naturally result in a more competitive or progressive political landscape. However, as this comparison shows, it is not enough for a state to have a large minority population; that population must see itself as a cohesive political unit with a shared sense of "Linked Fate" (Dawson, 1994).

In Georgia, the rigid Black-White binary of the "Sunbelt South" has forged a unified identity block. Because the social and political lines are clearly drawn, the "utility" of collective voting is obvious and the "demand" for change is high-pressure and focused. In Louisiana, the legacy of Creole tripartite structures and regional Catholic-Protestant splits functions as an "Identity Buffer." This fragmentation ensures that even as the state's demographics shift, the political identity remains anchored in localized parish patronage rather than a statewide movement. As Hochschild (2016) might argue, the "Deep Story" of the Louisiana voter is not just one of race, but of a complicated cultural heritage that elites can exploit to prevent a unified front. The "punch" of this analysis is clear: Georgia's identity structure creates a high-pressure demand for competition, while Louisiana's identity structure creates a fragmented stasis that reinforces elite control.

III. Patterns of Mobilization and Civic Infrastructure

The divergent political paths of Georgia and Louisiana cannot be explained solely by economic shifts or elite power structures; they are equally the product of the physical and digital labor of moving voters to the polls, commonly referred to as the "ground game." While Chapter IV analyzes the

institutional levers of power, this chapter examines the human engine that activates them. As established in the theoretical framework, mobilization functions as the bridge between voter demand and institutional supply. Demographic presence alone does not generate political change. Organized participation is necessary to activate identity-based grievances and exert pressure on institutions.

This dynamic is best understood through Larry Bartels' (2016) analysis of political influence. Bartels argues that in a system of unequal responsiveness, the "default" state of a political institution is to ignore the preferences of low-income and marginalized constituencies unless they are compelled to respond through high-intensity mobilization. Georgia has emerged as the national exemplar of year-round organizing by treating civic engagement as permanent infrastructure rather than a seasonal campaign event. Conversely, Louisiana's mobilization efforts remain fragmented, top-down, and largely dormant between election cycles. By examining third-party organizations, religious institutions, HBCUs, and party-level investment, this chapter demonstrates that Georgia's permanent infrastructure expanded and activated its electorate, while Louisiana's reliance on patronage networks and limited national support left much of its political potential unrealized.

To understand why Georgia's mobilization infrastructure succeeded where Louisiana's failed, it is necessary to examine not just the organizations that drove turnout, but the conditions that made those organizations possible. Mobilization does not emerge from a vacuum. It requires a combination of civic trust, institutional access, and a shared sense of political utility among the target population. In Georgia, these preconditions were built deliberately over decades through the slow accumulation of organizational capacity in Black churches, HBCUs, and community-based nonprofits. By the time the New Georgia Project launched its large-scale registration drives, it was not building infrastructure from scratch — it was connecting and amplifying networks that already existed. In Louisiana, no comparable foundation had been laid. The state's history of patronage politics actively discouraged the formation of independent civic infrastructure by making political access contingent on personal relationships with brokers rather than on organized collective action. This distinction — between infrastructure that is built from the

bottom up and access that is rented from the top down — is the central fault line of this chapter. It explains not only why Georgia's mobilization succeeded, but why Louisiana's political potential has remained chronically unrealized despite the presence of a large, Democratic-leaning electorate.

3.1 The "Stacey Abrams" Model: Organizing as Permanent Infrastructure

Georgia's transformation from a reliably Republican state into a competitive battleground was the result of a deliberate, long-term investment in civic infrastructure. Following her tenure as House Minority Leader, Stacey Abrams advanced a strategy that shifted away from the traditional Democratic focus on persuading white moderate "swing" voters. Instead, the Abrams model prioritized the mobilization of the "New American Majority," which consists of Black, Latino, Asian-American, and young voters who had been historically overlooked in statewide contests.

Central to this strategy was the "1.2 Million" calculation. Abrams and her allies identified approximately 1.2 million eligible but unregistered voters of color in Georgia. To engage this population, Abrams founded the New Georgia Project in 2014 and later Fair Fight Action in 2018. Unlike traditional campaigns that dissolve after Election Day, these organizations were designed as year-round civic institutions. They conducted voter registration, issue-based organizing, and community education outside of traditional electoral cycles.

This model fundamentally altered the "Deep Story" of the Georgian voter. As Arlie Russell Hochschild (2016) describes, voters often feel a sense of "stagnation" or a feeling that they are being passed over by the system. By creating a permanent presence, these organizations provided a counter-narrative of agency. Between 2016 and 2020, Georgia experienced significant increases in registration among historically underrepresented groups. Black registered voters increased by approximately 130,000, which was the largest numerical increase of any racial group during that period. During the same window, Latino and Asian-American registration rose by roughly 60% and 55%, respectively (U.S. Census Bureau, 2024). By 2020, white registered voters accounted for only 53% of the

electorate, down from 63% in 2008. These changes reflected not merely demographic growth, but the organized activation of that growth through a sustained supply of mobilization resources.

National party investment reinforced this infrastructure, highlighting the disparity in institutional support between the two states. Through the Democratic National Committee's State Partnership Program, most state parties receive baseline operational support. In the late 2010s, non-competitive states such as Louisiana often received around $15,000 per month. Georgia, however, began receiving millions in supplemental funding once it was designated a competitive battleground in 2018. In addition to baseline support, the Democratic Senatorial Campaign Committee and Democratic Congressional Campaign Committee invested heavily in coordinated field offices, data infrastructure, and voter protection programs.

By contrast, the Louisiana Democratic Party largely remained dependent on modest monthly operational funding with limited coordinated expansion. This disparity reflects Bartels' (2016) theory of political inequality: where a state demonstrates mobilized demand and electoral viability, national actors amplify its infrastructure. Conversely, Louisiana's limited competitiveness reinforced its peripheral status in national funding strategies, creating a self-reinforcing loop of under-mobilization. This lack of "Institutional Supply" for mobilization in Louisiana ensures that the "Deep Story" for many marginalized voters remains one of abandonment rather than engagement.

3.2 The 2025 Dissolution: Infrastructure as a War of Attrition

The dissolution of the New Georgia Project (NGP) in late 2025 provides a critical opportunity to test the "permanent infrastructure" thesis. At first glance, the collapse of the state's most prominent mobilization entity might seem to undermine the argument that Georgia has built a lasting "supply" of competition. However, a deeper analysis suggests that the death of NGP actually proves that mobilization is an ongoing war of attrition between voter demand and institutional resistance.

Larry Bartels (2016) notes that when a political system feels threatened by an increase in "responsiveness," it will move to restrict the "supply" of that responsiveness. The relentless legal and legislative pressure placed on NGP—including multiple investigations into its registration tactics and changes to the state's non-profit donor laws—represents a deliberate institutional "veto." Yet, the dissolution of NGP does not mean the dissolution of the "New Georgia" electorate.

The true "permanent infrastructure" is not a single 501(c)(3) organization; it is the "human capital" and "organizational memory" that NGP left behind. The thousands of organizers trained by the project, the proprietary data sets on "unaligned" voters, and the shift in the "Deep Story" (Hochschild, 2016) of the Georgia voter are now part of the state's political DNA. Unlike Louisiana, where mobilization is "episodic" and dies with a candidate's campaign, Georgia has developed a "modular" infrastructure. When one entity falls, its components—donors, data, and boots-on-the-ground—are rapidly absorbed by other organizations in the ecosystem. The dissolution of NGP is therefore a proof of concept: it shows that the "demand" for competition in Georgia has become so powerful that the state's power structures were forced to use their most extreme legal tools to dismantle it. The stasis is broken not because an organization exists, but because the capacity to organize has become a permanent feature of the landscape.

3.3 The Black Church: From the Pulpit to the Polls

While secular organizations provided the data-driven architecture of Georgia's political transformation, the Black Church supplied the moral authority and communal anchor necessary to mobilize voters. In both Georgia and Louisiana, Black churches have historically functioned as the central "institutional supply" for civic life. However, a significant divergence exists in the coordination and scale of these efforts. In Georgia, the Black Church serves as a statewide organizational engine, whereas in Louisiana, its influence is often restricted to local parishes.

In Georgia, the "Souls to the Polls" tradition evolved into a coordinated statewide mobilization system. This practice is a manifestation of what Hochschild (2016) describes as a narrative of collective agency; it frames the act of voting as a spiritual and moral obligation to the community. Congregations move collectively from Sunday services to early voting sites, supported by church buses and voter protection teams. Statewide African Methodist Episcopal (AME) and Baptist networks ensure that civic participation is preached and organized across hundreds of congregations simultaneously. This creates a "Deep Story" of empowerment that counters the feeling of being "left behind" by secular political institutions.

The effectiveness of this model prompted significant institutional resistance, reflecting Bartels' (2016) theory that political systems often react to exclude newly mobilized, lower-income constituencies. Following the 2020 election, Georgia enacted Senate Bill 202, which restricted Sunday voting hours, reduced the number of ballot drop boxes, and prohibited "line relief," the distribution of water or food to voters waiting in long lines. These provisions disproportionately affected majority-Black precincts in counties such as Fulton and Gwinnett, where church-based mobilization was strongest. Despite these restrictions, the coordinated religious infrastructure demonstrated profound resilience. Sunday turnout levels remained high in subsequent cycles, proving that when mobilization is rooted in deep-seated identity and communal faith, it can partially bypass institutional barriers designed to discourage participation.

In Louisiana, religious mobilization remains localized and fragmented. While powerful individual churches in New Orleans and Baton Rouge conduct significant turnout drives, they lack the statewide coordination seen in Georgia. This fragmentation is exacerbated by Louisiana's unique electoral structures. The Jungle Primary system further fragments religious mobilization by encouraging intra-party competition, often pitting different congregations or local leaders against one another. As a result, Louisiana's Black turnout in non-presidential elections consistently lags behind Georgia's. This disparity

reflects a mobilization gap rather than a demographic deficiency, confirming that without statewide "institutional supply" for organizing, voter demand remains politically diffuse.

3.4 HBCUs Political Incubators

Historically Black Colleges and Universities (HBCUs) function as essential engines of youth mobilization, yet their impact differs substantially between Georgia and Louisiana due to geographic and political concentration. In Georgia, the Atlanta University Center (AUC)—which comprises Clark Atlanta University, Morehouse College, and Spelman College—operates as a centralized hub of civic engagement. Nearly 10,000 students concentrated within a compact urban space create a dense, high-intensity organizing environment.

The physical geography of the AUC facilitates high-visibility events such as "Walk to the Polls." This transforms the act of voting into a collective ritual rather than an individual burden. This environment addresses the problem of "rational ignorance" that Bartels (2016) identifies as a barrier for young voters; when the cost of participation is lowered through walkable access and peer reinforcement, turnout naturally increases. Student engagement during recent election cycles has been substantial, with campus-based organizations feeding directly into statewide mobilization efforts. This has created a relational organizing pipeline in which student activists transition into professional roles within Georgia's permanent civic infrastructure, ensuring a self-sustaining cycle of leadership.

In contrast, Louisiana's HBCUs, including Grambling State University and Southern University, remain culturally significant but are geographically dispersed. Southern University is located in the southern part of the state in Baton Rouge, while Grambling is situated in a rural northern parish. This geographic distance prevents the creation of a "metropolitan gravity" that allows Georgia's students to influence statewide outcomes with such consistency. Furthermore, limited transportation infrastructure and a lack of on-campus polling options in Louisiana increase the "cost of participation" for students.

While student activism in Louisiana is vibrant, the absence of a centralized metropolitan cluster comparable to the Atlanta University Center weakens the state's capacity to scale youth mobilization. This reflects a broader trend of "unequal democracy" where the physical and legal barriers to voting are higher for student populations in Louisiana. Consequently, many of Louisiana's most politically active HBCU graduates often migrate to larger hubs like Atlanta for professional opportunities, leading to a "brain drain" that deprives Louisiana of the localized civic infrastructure necessary to challenge its existing power structures.

3.5 Louisiana: The Persistence of Patronage and Machine Politics

In contrast to Georgia's systems-based model of permanent organizing, Louisiana's mobilization efforts remain fragmented and candidate-centered. Rather than building a durable, year-round civic infrastructure, Louisiana relies on parish-level political machines. These machines, often anchored by local sheriffs, parish presidents, or influential Political Action Committees (PACs), serve as the primary gatekeepers of voter turnout. As Larry Bartels (2016) notes in his study of political responsiveness, when mobilization is controlled by localized elites, the system becomes predisposed toward "unequal democracy," where the preferences of the general electorate are secondary to the preservation of elite networks.

The "Jungle Primary" system—a unique Louisiana institution where all candidates run on a single ballot regardless of party—further reinforces this fragmentation. This electoral structure encourages candidates to cultivate personal, transactional vote-delivery networks rather than investing in a unified party infrastructure. Consequently, political energy is directed toward localized competition and internal rivalries rather than the kind of statewide coalition-building that reshaped Georgia. This creates a "Deep Story" in Louisiana where the voter is not a member of a statewide movement, but a client in a local exchange of favors and patronage (Hochschild, 2016).

This structure produces measurable and profound turnout disparities. In the 2023 gubernatorial election, Black voter turnout in Louisiana dropped sharply compared to recent presidential cycles, while white turnout remained significantly more resilient. Without a centralized organization bridging the geographic and cultural divides between New Orleans, Baton Rouge, and the rural northern parishes, the Democratic electorate remains siloed. This lack of "Institutional Supply" for mobilization ensures that the potential power of the state's minority and youth populations remains dormant.

Furthermore, patronage politics fundamentally alters the incentives for expansion. In a machine-based system, maintaining a predictable and manageable electorate is often more advantageous for brokers than expanding the voter rolls. A surge of new, unaligned voters—such as the youth surge seen in Georgia—threatens the control of local brokers and disrupts established networks of exchange. Consequently, Louisiana's mobilization model reinforces a "low-turnout equilibrium." This equilibrium sustains the political status quo, as the barriers to entry for new, non-aligned voters remain prohibitively high.

3.5.1 The "Brokerage" Bottleneck: Why Machines Fail to Scale

The persistence of these parish-level machines creates a "brokerage bottleneck" that prevents the scaling of political power. Larry Bartels (2016) argues that for a democracy to be responsive, the "Institutional Supply" must be capable of reaching the broad electorate. In Louisiana, the supply of political mobilization is "rented" rather than "owned" by the people. Because turnout is managed by local brokers (sheriffs and parish presidents), the political agenda remains focused on the narrow, transactional needs of the parish rather than the transformative needs of the state.

This contrast is best viewed through Michael Dawson's (1994) "Black Utility Heuristic." In Georgia, the permanent infrastructure signals to voters that their "Linked Fate" is tied to statewide outcomes, such as Senate control or judicial appointments. This makes the "utility" of voting high. In Louisiana's machine system, the heuristic is narrowed: the utility of the vote is often perceived as being

tied to local patronage—a municipal job, a paved road, or a personal favor from a broker. When a voter perceives that their vote only has utility at the micro-local level, they are less likely to turn out for statewide or national contests where the "favors" are less tangible.

This is why the "low-turnout equilibrium" mentioned previously is so difficult to break. In Georgia, the systems-based model destroyed the need for brokers; in Louisiana, the brokers are the only people with the "keys" to the electorate. Consequently, the state's political energy is trapped in a series of disconnected "silos." Without a mechanism to unify the Creole voters of the south, the Anglo-Protestant voters of the north, and the urban centers of New Orleans and Baton Rouge, Louisiana's "demand" for change remains a collection of local whispers rather than a statewide roar.

3.6 Case Study: "Souls to the Polls" vs. The Parish Machine

A comparative analysis of Sunday voting practices illustrates the divergence between Georgia's coordinated civic infrastructure and Louisiana's localized patronage. In Georgia, Sunday voting has evolved into a high-intensity statewide mobilization event. This practice is embedded within a synergy of religious and secular organizational networks that treat the act of voting as a communal celebration. In counties such as Fulton and Gwinnett, early voting totals often dictate the final margins of statewide contests, reflecting the durable coordination between Black churches, professional organizers, and national party infrastructure.

The Georgia model utilizes "trusted messengers" to navigate the "Deep Story" of the voter, framing the ballot box as a tool of moral and social resilience (Hochschild, 2016). This messaging is backed by a sophisticated logistical apparatus that manages everything from transportation to "voter protection" at polling sites. Even as the state legislature introduced barriers to this model through SB 202, the infrastructure proved flexible enough to sustain high participation levels by pivoting to intensified early-week and weekend outreach.

In Louisiana, Sunday voting lacks comparable statewide synchronization. Mobilization remains localized and transactional, often tied to the personal influence of specific candidates rather than an integrated, year-round system. Early turnout in parishes such as East Baton Rouge and Orleans consistently fails to replicate the coordinated "surge" seen in Georgia's metropolitan hubs. In the 2024 primary and general cycles, Louisiana saw significantly lower rates of early-vote adoption among young and minority voters compared to Georgia, illustrating a clear "mobilization gap."

The contrast between these two states reveals two distinct political trajectories. Georgia has successfully integrated culture, infrastructure, and national investment into a scalable system that converts demographic change into competitive electoral outcomes. This represents a high-functioning "Institutional Supply" that meets the rising "Voter Demand." Louisiana, conversely, remains tethered to a model of localized patronage that struggles to expand beyond traditional territorial influence. As Bartels (2016) suggests, without a fundamental change in the electoral and organizational "supply," the preferences of the under-mobilized in Louisiana will continue to have minimal impact on the state's political direction. The divergence, therefore, is not a matter of population difference, but a difference in the organizational labor required to turn a population into a constituency.

3.7 The Digital Ground Game: Tech Hubs vs. the Digital Divide

A modern factor in mobilization that distinguishes Georgia from Louisiana is the use of digital infrastructure. Georgia, anchored by Atlanta's status as a "Tech Hub," has benefited from a sophisticated, data-driven "Digital Ground Game." Organizations like the New Georgia Project utilized proprietary apps and SMS-based "relational organizing" tools to reach younger, mobile voters who do not respond to traditional canvassing.

In Georgia, the "supply" of technical talent from institutions like Georgia Tech and the "Silicon Peach" ecosystem allowed for the creation of a year-round digital presence. This infrastructure lowered the "cost of information" (Bartels, 2016) for voters, making it easier to navigate Georgia's changing

election laws. For example, during the 2024 cycle, digital "Voter Protection" dashboards allowed organizers to track ballot rejections in real-time in Fulton County. This level of technical scale is something that Louisiana's fragmented party structure has yet to achieve.

Louisiana, conversely, suffers from a significant "Digital Divide." According to the FCC (2025), rural parishes in Northern Louisiana have some of the lowest broadband adoption rates in the country. This physical limitation prevents the scaling of the "Digital Ground Game." While candidates in New Orleans use social media effectively, there is no statewide digital infrastructure capable of bridging the gap between urban centers and rural Black Belt parishes. This reinforces the "Institutional Stasis" discussed in Chapter IV: if the "supply" of political information is restricted by a lack of broadband access, the "demand" for change remains politically isolated.

3.7.1 The Political Consequences of the Digital Divide

The "Digital Divide" in Louisiana's rural parishes (FCC, 2025) does more than limit internet speeds; it constricts the "Political Horizon" of the electorate. In Georgia, high-speed connectivity in the "Silicon Peach" corridor allows for a continuous, low-cost "supply" of political information through relational organizing apps and targeted social media. In contrast, the lack of broadband in Northern Louisiana forces mobilization back into traditional, high-cost methods like mailers and physical canvassing, which are easily controlled by local parish machines.

This divide creates a tiered system of citizenship. In a "Digital Ground Game," the voter is part of a statewide narrative. In a "Broadband Desert," the voter remains siloed within the "Deep Story" of their local parish. This reinforces the institutional stasis: if you cannot see a statewide movement for change because your digital window is shuttered, the "demand" for that change remains localized and politically toothless.

3.8 Linked Fate and the Utility of the Vote: A Dawsonian Analysis

The divergence in mobilization is not just about logistics; it is about the "Black Utility Heuristic" as defined by Michael Dawson (1994). Dawson posits that Black voters utilize the "linked fate" concept—the belief that what happens to the group happens to the individual—to simplify political decision-making. In Georgia, the mobilization infrastructure (the "supply") successfully signaled that the vote has high utility. When Stacey Abrams or Raphael Warnock spoke at the AUC, they reinforced a narrative where collective action leads to tangible institutional responsiveness, such as student loan relief or federal judicial appointments. This creates a "feedback loop" where the high utility of the vote encourages further participation.

In Louisiana, however, "linked fate" is strained by the "Petro-State" economy. Because the state's economic lifeblood is tied to an industry that often stands in opposition to the policy preferences of Black voters (such as environmental regulations in "Cancer Alley"), the utility of the vote appears lower. Applying Larry Bartels' theory of "unequal democracy," we see that when a state's elite are more responsive to industry lobbyists than to a mobilized base, the heuristic of "linked fate" can lead to political withdrawal rather than activation. If the group is ignored by the state regardless of turnout, the "utility" of participating diminishes, leading to the "episodic mobilization" seen in Louisiana's recent gubernatorial cycles.

3.8.1 The Fractured "Linked Fate" of the Gulf South

To fully apply Michael Dawson's (1994) "Black Utility Heuristic," we must look back at the identity structures discussed in Chapter II. In Georgia, the rigid Black-White binary creates a high degree of "Linked Fate." Because the social boundaries are clear, the "utility" of collective voting is obvious. In Louisiana, however, the tripartite legacy of Creole, Catholic, and Anglo-Protestant identities fractures this sense of group destiny.

When "Linked Fate" is fractured, the "Utility Heuristic" breaks down. A voter in New Orleans may feel their destiny is tied to their parish or their specific cultural heritage rather than a statewide racial

coalition. This "Identity Fragmentation" makes it nearly impossible for mobilization leaders to create a unified "demand." As a result, Louisiana's voters often fall into what Bartels calls "Rational Ignorance"—if the group is too divided to win, the rational choice for the individual is to disengage. Georgia's 'permanent infrastructure' succeeded specifically because it had a more unified identity block to activate; Louisiana's leaders must first solve the identity fragmentation problem before a unified mobilization infrastructure can take root — a challenge Georgia never faced at the same scale.

IV. Political Power Structures and Institutional Evolution

The divergence between Georgia and Louisiana is not merely a product of shifting demographics. It is the result of how political power is structured, inherited, and contested through formal institutions. While both states emerged from the "Solid South" era of Democratic hegemony, their institutional trajectories have moved in opposite directions. Georgia's power structure has proven fluid, transitioning through distinct elite handoffs from rural "Talmadge-era" elites to business-centric "Sunbelt Republicans," and finally to a multi-ethnic, suburban-driven coalition. In contrast, Louisiana's power structure remains static, anchored in an extractive, elite-driven model that prioritizes institutional stability over partisan transformation.

This contrast illustrates Larry Bartels' (2016) theory that political institutions do not merely reflect the population; they shape the "institutional supply" of policy and power. In Georgia, the supply of power has evolved to accommodate new economic and social demands. In Louisiana, the supply remains captured by entrenched interests, leading to the "unequal democracy" Bartels describes where the system is unresponsive to the shifting preferences of the broader electorate.

4.1 Georgia: The Collapse of Rural Dominance and the Suburban Handover

To understand Georgia's modern competitiveness, one must first analyze the institutional mechanisms that once rendered it a monolith of rural conservative power. For much of the twentieth century, Georgia's political structure was defined by the County Unit System. Formally established by the

Neill Primary Act of 1917, this system functioned as a state-level version of the Electoral College but with a drastic rural bias. Each of Georgia's 159 counties was assigned between two and six "unit votes." Because the smallest rural counties collectively held a majority of these units despite representing less than a third of the population, rural white elites held a structural veto over the state's executive branch (New Georgia Encyclopedia, 2024).

This system allowed populist segregationists such as Eugene Talmadge to win the governorship even while losing the popular vote, effectively insulating the state's power structure from the growing influence of urban Atlanta (Talmadge, 1946). This institutional insulation created a "Deep Story" for rural white Georgians that their cultural and political dominance was the natural state of the land (Hochschild, 2016). However, the 1963 Supreme Court decision in *Gray v. Sanders*, which established the "one person, one vote" principle, signaled the end of this era. As the legal "moat" protecting rural elites evaporated, the state's political center of gravity began a decades-long migration toward the metropolitan north. This shift represents a transition from a closed institutional system to a more fluid one, capable of eventually responding to a more diverse set of voters.

4.1.1 The Rise of "Business Republicanism" and the Creative Economy

As the rural-dominated Democratic machine collapsed, it was replaced by a pragmatic "Business Republicanism." This era, spearheaded by governors such as Nathan Deal, moved away from the "culture war" focus prevalent in other Southern states and toward a "Sunbelt" growth model. By marketing Georgia as the "No. 1 State for Business," the Republican establishment focused on corporate recruitment, infrastructure, and the diversification of the state's economic portfolio.

A landmark moment in this transition was the expansion of the Georgia Entertainment Industry Investment Act in 2008. By offering a 30 percent tax credit for film and television productions, the state successfully lured a massive, high-wage industry away from California. This policy created an "economic bypass." While rural areas continued to see population decline or stagnation, the metro region experienced

an explosion of a new "creative class." By 2024, the film industry was responsible for over $4.1 billion in annual spending and nearly 60,000 direct jobs (Georgia Department of Economic Development, 2024).

This economic pivot brought a mobile, college-educated, and racially diverse workforce that fundamentally lacked the cultural ties to the state's traditionalist past. These new residents brought a different "Deep Story"—one rooted in cosmopolitanism and economic opportunity rather than agrarian heritage (Hochschild, 2016). This shift mirrors Bartels' (2016) observation that economic transitions can force institutional changes. As the state's tax base shifted from rural land to urban technology and film, the political "supply" of the Republican party had to adapt, creating a suburban-urban coalition that eventually became too diverse for the traditional conservative platform to contain, leading to the narrow margins seen in recent elections.

4.1.2 Case Study: The Suburban Realignment of Gwinnett County

The most significant evidence of Georgia's fluid power structure is the "suburban flip" of Gwinnett County. Once the bedrock of the "Gingrich Revolution" and a reliably conservative stronghold, Gwinnett has undergone one of the most rapid demographic and political transformations in United States history. In 1990, the county was over 90 percent white. By July 2024, U.S. Census data confirmed that Gwinnett's population had surpassed one million, with "White alone, not Hispanic" residents making up less than 30 percent of the population (U.S. Census Bureau, 2024).

This demographic pressure successfully broke the hold of the old guard on local and state institutions. In the 2024 General Election, Gwinnett cemented its status as a Democratic stronghold, with the Democratic presidential nominee securing 57.6 percent of the vote (Gwinnett County Board of Elections, 2024). This represents the final stage of the "fluid" power shift: the transition from rural elites to business moderates, and finally to a multi-ethnic, urbanized coalition. This progression suggests that Georgia's political institutions were flexible enough to adapt to change. As Hochschild (2016) posits, the "Deep Story" of these new suburban voters is often one of inclusion and professional mobility, which

contrasts sharply with the traditionalist narratives of the rural past. Georgia's ability to provide an "institutional supply" for these new voters—through competitive elections and representative local government—allowed the state to pivot where others have stalled.

4.1.3 Re-Writing the Deep Story: Gwinnett County as a Laboratory

Arlie Hochschild (2016) argues that the "Deep Story" of the conservative voter often involves a sense of "waiting in line" for the American Dream, only to see others "cut in front" via government intervention. In the 1990s, Gwinnett County was the headquarters of this narrative, serving as a stronghold for Newt Gingrich's "Contract with America". However, as the county's demographic "supply" shifted—becoming one of the most diverse counties in the Southeast—the Deep Story itself began to fragment.

The "suburban flip" occurred because the mobilization infrastructure successfully introduced a competing Deep Story: one of "Suburban Cosmopolitanism". Unlike the rural "Talmadge-era" elites who viewed power as a zero-sum game of racial hierarchy, the new Gwinnett electorate viewed power through the lens of "Institutional Fluidity". They prioritized transit, school funding, and tech-sector growth over traditionalist moral crusades. This is a direct application of Bartels' (2016) observation on economic transitions: as the tax base shifted from traditional land-owners to a diverse, mobile workforce, the political system was forced to open its "responsiveness" to stay viable. Louisiana's lack of a "Gwinnett equivalent" means its institutions never faced this internal psychological and economic pressure to evolve.

4.2 Louisiana: The "Petro-State" and Institutional Inertia

While Georgia's political institutions proved flexible enough to adapt to a diversifying economy, Louisiana's power structure remains defined by a "Petro-State" model that prioritizes institutional inertia. In political science, an "extractive state" is one where the government derives a massive portion of its revenue from natural resources rather than a diverse tax base. This creates a top-down power dynamic where political elites are more responsive to industry lobbyists than to grassroots demographic shifts. This

is a primary example of what Bartels (2016) calls "unequal democracy," where the policy preferences of the economically powerful are institutionalized, while the needs of the broader public are marginalized. In Louisiana, the fossil fuel and petrochemical industries have historically functioned as the state's primary "economic governors," creating a political landscape that is structurally resistant to transformation.

4.2.1 The Economic Hegemony of "The Company" and the LOGA Lobby

The dominance of the oil and gas industry in Louisiana is not merely economic; it is institutional. For decades, the industry accounted for nearly 40 percent of the state's total revenue. While that figure fluctuates with global market prices, the political influence of organizations such as the Louisiana Oil and Gas Association (LOGA) and the Louisiana Mid-Continent Oil and Gas Association (LMOGA) remains absolute. "These groups act as 'institutional anchors,' ensuring that regardless of which party holds the governorship, the state's legislative priorities remain fixed on industrial deregulation and the preservation of the Louisiana Mineral Code (Title 31 of the Revised Statutes), which serves as the statutory backbone of the state's extractive economy (Louisiana State Law Institute, 2024)."

In 2025, this hegemony was visible during the legislative session led by Governor Jeff Landry. The administration successfully pushed through a package of "Energy Independence" bills designed to streamline permitting for carbon capture and enhance production incentives. Unlike Georgia's film tax credits, which invited a new, diverse professional class into the state, Louisiana's energy incentives reinforce the existing industrial workforce. This creates a "closed loop" of power: the state's economic survival depends on an industry that is culturally and politically aligned with the conservative status quo. This "deep story" of industrial loyalty prevents the kind of "economic bypass" seen in Atlanta (Hochschild, 2016).

4.2.2 Case Study: The "Jungle Primary" and the Stifling of Partisan Infrastructure

One of the most unique and restrictive features of Louisiana's power structure is its election system. Formally known as the "Jungle Primary," this system allows all candidates to run on a single ballot regardless of party affiliation. While proponents argue this system encourages moderation, it has historically functioned as a stabilizer for entrenched elites. Because a candidate can win outright with over 50 percent of the vote in the first round, the system prevents the minority party from building the kind of long-term, year-round partisan infrastructure that was utilized in Georgia.

4.2.3 The Closed Primary Transition: A Different Tool for the Same Stasis

There is a fundamental conceptual tension in Louisiana's institutional history that requires a deeper reckoning. For decades, political scientists argued that Louisiana's "Jungle Primary" was the primary engine of its political stasis. By allowing all candidates to run on a single ballot, the system discouraged the formation of the year-round, professionalized partisan infrastructure that Larry Bartels (2016) identifies as the essential "supply" of political competition. In the Jungle Primary era, politics was candidate-centered and patronage-based; candidates like Edwin Edwards built personal empires that bypassed party loyalty, leaving the "institutional supply" of the state fragmented and weak.

However, the 2024 transition to a "closed" primary system via Act 1 of the First Extraordinary Session represents a move toward "partisan consolidation" that is likely to produce the same result of stasis through a different mechanism. This massive institutional shift, estimated to cost taxpayers as much as $47 million over five years (Louisiana Secretary of State, 2024), is not an attempt to open competition, but to "capture" it. In Georgia, a closed primary system allows a multi-ethnic coalition to challenge the incumbent party because the "demand" for change is supported by a massive, independent mobilization infrastructure. In Louisiana, no such independent infrastructure exists at scale.

By moving to a closed system, the Republican supermajority is effectively narrowing the "Institutional Supply." This change eliminates the possibility of "crossover voting," where moderate or independent voters could influence the outcome of a primary. Instead, it forces voters into rigid partisan lanes in a state where the minority party remains chronically underfunded and decentralized. This is what Bartels (2016) calls "defensive institutionalism." If the Jungle Primary created stasis through fragmentation, Act 1 creates stasis through fortification. It ensures that the only "supply" of political power is vetted by the existing party gatekeepers, effectively insulating the state from the kind of bottom-up, suburban-led realignment that transformed Georgia. Both systems—though functionally opposite—serve the same extractive purpose: they prevent the "demand" of a diversifying electorate from ever reaching the "supply" of actual power.

4.2.4 The Fragmented Core: Why New Orleans is not Atlanta

A critical factor in Louisiana's stasis is the geographical fragmentation of its Democratic base. In Georgia, the Democratic Party is anchored in a singular, massive, and rapidly growing metropolitan engine: Atlanta. In contrast, Louisiana's Democratic strength is divided between New Orleans, Baton Rouge, and Shreveport. New Orleans, once the undisputed political center of the state, has seen its population and economic influence stagnate relative to the surrounding "suburban-industrial" parishes such as Jefferson and St. Tammany.

This fragmentation prevents the formation of a unified political "Deep Story" for the state's urban voters (Hochschild, 2016). In Georgia, the Atlanta metro area acts as a "Primate City," a singular gravity well that pulls the entire state toward a more competitive, fluid political future. Atlanta's growth allows for a consolidated media market and a centralized organizing hub. Conversely, Louisiana's urban centers function as "islands" of Democratic strength, isolated from one another by vast rural stretches dominated by the extractive industry. Without a singular metropolitan anchor to challenge the state's rural-industrial legislative alliance, Louisiana's power structure remains fractured and localized.

4.3 Consequences: Fluidity vs. Stasis

The divergence between Georgia and Louisiana is ultimately a study in the responsiveness of political institutions. The structural evolution of these two states suggests that demographics alone do not dictate political outcomes. Rather, the way power is filtered through economic and electoral systems determines whether a state evolves or remains "frozen" in a previous era. Georgia's trajectory represents a model of Institutional Fluidity, while Louisiana's represents a model of Institutional Stasis.

4.3.1 The Mechanical Result of Fluidity in Georgia

In Georgia, the breakdown of the County Unit System and the subsequent rise of "Business Republicanism" created a marketplace for political competition. Because Georgia's economy moved away from traditional agrarian extraction and toward a "knowledge and creative economy" (technology, film, and logistics), the state's political elite were forced to court a more diverse, mobile, and educated workforce. This created what Larry Bartels (2016) might describe as an "opening of responsiveness."

This fluidity allowed for a feedback loop: the pro-business policies of the 2000s invited the very demographic groups that would eventually challenge the Republican supermajority in the 2020s. This environment proved fertile for sophisticated, grassroots-driven mobilization efforts. Because the power structure was no longer tied to a singular, entrenched rural elite, organizations like the New Georgia Project and Fair Fight could identify "cracks" in the suburban ring of Atlanta. The result is a "Contested State" where political power is no longer inherited but must be earned in every election cycle. In this environment, the institutions are sensitive to even small shifts in voter behavior, leading to the rapid partisan realignment witnessed between 2016 and 2024.

4.3.2 The Mechanical Result of Stasis in Louisiana

Conversely, Louisiana's "Petro-State" model has acted as a stabilizer that prevents external political shocks from altering the state's trajectory. Because the state's economic lifeblood is tied to a

singular industrial complex—oil, gas, and chemicals—the political elite remain anchored to a workforce and a lobby that favor traditionalist, conservative governance. This is a classic example of "unequal democracy," where the institutional supply is captured by a specific economic sector (Bartels, 2016).

Furthermore, the long-standing use of the Jungle Primary served to de-nationalize Louisiana's internal politics for decades. By focusing on personality and patronage rather than partisan infrastructure, Louisiana effectively avoided the nationalization of politics that made Georgia a battleground. Even as the state moves toward a closed primary system in 2026, it is doing so from a position of Republican super-dominance. This move is likely to reinforce the existing power structure rather than opening it to competition. Louisiana's institutions are built for endurance; they are designed to resist the "winds of change" that have already transformed its neighbors to the east.

4.4 The Judicial Veto: Redistricting and the Battle for "Supply"

The final mechanism of institutional stasis in Louisiana, and a key point of divergence with Georgia, is the role of the judiciary in redistricting. Larry Bartels (2016) argues that the "design" of electoral districts is the ultimate form of "Institutional Supply." In the 2020 redistricting cycle, both states faced legal challenges under Section 2 of the Voting Rights Act (VRA).

In Georgia, the Republican-led legislature was forced to concede to the growth of the Atlanta metro area. While they maintained a "partisan gerrymander," the sheer density of the minority population in the suburbs made it impossible to fully "dilute" the vote without violating federal law. The "Institutional Fluidity" of Georgia meant that the maps, while skewed, had to accommodate the reality of a 50/50 state.

In Louisiana, the institutional response was one of "maximum resistance." Following the 2020 Census, the legislature passed a map that maintained only one majority-Black congressional district out of six, despite the state being one-third Black. It took a multi-year legal battle—reaching the Supreme Court

in *Ardoin v. Robinson* (2024)—to force the state to create a second majority-Black district. This "Judicial Veto" represents the final wall of Louisiana's Petro-State model. By using every legal and procedural tool to delay the expansion of minority representation, Louisiana's elites successfully maintained an "Institutional Stasis" that Georgia's more fluid business-centric model had already abandoned.

4.4.1 Synthesis: Why the Paths Diverged

The consequence of these two different structures is that Georgia has become a laboratory for the "New South," while Louisiana remains the standard-bearer for the "Deep South" status quo. Georgia's power structure proved to be a "bridge" to a new electorate, while Louisiana's power structure acted as a "buffer."

This divergence confirms the core thesis: political change requires both the "demand" of a changing population and the "supply" of responsive institutions. In Georgia, these two forces met and created a swing state. In Louisiana, the demand exists, but it is stifled by an institutional supply that remains captured by an extractive elite. As we look toward the 2026 and 2028 election cycles, the divergence will likely only sharpen. Georgia will continue to function as a high-stakes, competitive swing state, while Louisiana will likely remain a reliably conservative stronghold, bolstered by a political machinery that prioritizes institutional permanence over democratic fluidity.

4.5 The Material Basis of Stasis: Revenue Streams and Elite Autonomy

To further engage with Bartels' (2016) *Unequal Democracy*, we must examine the "material supply" of the two states. Georgia's transition to a "knowledge and creative economy" (film, tech, and logistics) required a political environment that was perceived as stable, inclusive, and modern to attract corporate investment. This created an incentive for "Business Republicans" to occasionally check the impulses of the more traditionalist wing of their party, creating the "cracks" that organizers like Fair Fight could exploit.

In contrast, Louisiana's "Petro-State" model grants political elites a level of autonomy from the general public. When the state's revenue is derived from severance taxes on oil and gas rather than a broad-based income tax from a diverse workforce, the "opening of responsiveness" is much narrower. As Hochschild (2016) observed in the Bayou, even when the industry causes environmental or economic harm, the "Deep Story" of industrial loyalty remains a powerful stabilizer. This creates a "stabilizing loop" where the economic "supply" reinforces the political "stasis," making it nearly impossible for demographic "demand" to alter the state's trajectory without a fundamental shift in its economic foundation.

V. Divergence Over Time

Political divergence rarely occurs as a single, abrupt rupture. Instead, it accumulates gradually through the persistent layering of identity structures, mobilization capacity, and institutional incentives. Georgia and Louisiana did not suddenly become distinct political entities in the twenty-first century; rather, small variations in religious identity, racial categorization, economic organization, and party investment compounded over decades. These differences produced distinct political cultures and electoral trajectories that have now hardened into self-reinforcing systems.

5.1 The Early Divergence: Small Differences, Large Consequences

The divergence between Georgia and Louisiana did not begin in the twenty-first century. Its roots stretch back to the mid-twentieth century, when small structural differences in religious organization, urban growth, and economic investment began compounding in ways that would not become fully visible for decades. In the immediate post-civil rights era, both states appeared to be tracking along the same trajectory. Both shifted from Democratic to Republican dominance during the 1970s and 1980s as the "Solid South" realigned. Both maintained majority-white electorates that responded strongly to the racial and cultural appeals of the emerging Republican coalition. And both possessed large Black electorates

that remained loyal to the Democratic Party but lacked the organizational infrastructure to translate that loyalty into statewide power.

The first signs of divergence appeared not in electoral outcomes but in economic geography. Atlanta's emergence as a "Sunbelt" city during the 1970s and 1980s created a metropolitan engine that Louisiana's cities never developed at comparable scale. The growth of Hartsfield-Jackson Atlanta International Airport as a logistics hub, the expansion of Georgia Tech and Emory University as research institutions, and the deliberate recruitment of corporate headquarters by successive Georgia governors created the conditions for a new kind of electorate — mobile, educated, and economically tied to a cosmopolitan professional culture rather than to the extractive industries that continued to anchor Louisiana's economy. These economic differences did not immediately produce political differences. But they planted the seeds of a demographic divergence that would eventually force Georgia's institutions to adapt or lose relevance.

In Georgia, the interaction of clear partisan identity, permanent mobilization infrastructure, and a diversifying economy created a self-reinforcing feedback loop of increasing competitiveness. Each cycle of mobilization produced narrower margins, which attracted more national investment, which lowered the cost of participation further. In Louisiana, the opposite dynamic took hold. Fragmented identity, episodic mobilization, and an extractive economy produced a stabilizing loop where stasis reinforced itself. National parties read these signals and withheld investment, deepening the 'Deep Story' of abandonment among marginalized voters. These two trajectories did not emerge overnight — they compounded across decades of small structural differences until they hardened into the distinct political cultures visible today.

5.2 The Acceleration Period: 2008–2020

If the early divergence was slow and structural, the period between 2008 and 2020 was the acceleration. Barack Obama's 2008 presidential campaign represented the first major test of Georgia's emerging demographic potential. Obama lost Georgia by five points — a margin that, in any previous era,

would have confirmed the state's status as safely Republican. But the nature of that loss told a different story. Obama's campaign dramatically increased Black voter registration and turnout across the Atlanta metropolitan area, demonstrating for the first time that the state's minority electorate could be activated at scale. The loss was close enough to signal possibility, and that signal was not lost on the organizers who would go on to build the infrastructure that eventually flipped the state.

Louisiana in 2008 told a different story. Obama lost the state by nearly twenty points, a margin that reflected not just partisan preference but the structural barriers — fragmented mobilization, patronage-dependent turnout operations, and the absence of a metropolitan organizing hub. That prevented the state's Democratic-leaning electorate from expressing its full potential. The contrast between these two losing margins is instructive. Georgia's five-point loss in 2008 functioned as an organizing catalyst. Louisiana's twenty-point loss functioned as a discouragement. National Democratic strategists read these signals and made investment decisions accordingly, deepening the infrastructure gap between the two states during precisely the years when Georgia's permanent civic organizations were taking root. By 2016, the compounding effect of these divergent investment patterns was beginning to show in registration data. By 2020, it was visible in election results. The divergence that had been building for decades finally became impossible to ignore.

Table 1. Presidential Election Margins in Georgia and Louisiana, 2008–2024

Election Year	Georgia	Louisiana	National Winner
2008	R +5.20	R +18.63	Obama (D)
2012	R +7.80	R +17.20	Obama (D)
2016	R +5.09	R +19.64	Trump (R)
2020	D +0.23	R +18.61	Biden (D)
2024	R +2.18	R +22.01	Trump (R)

Note: Margins expressed as the difference between the winning party's vote share and the losing party's vote share. Source: Leip, David. Dave Leip's Atlas of U.S. Presidential Elections, 2024. uselectionatlas.org.

Table 1 illustrates this divergence in concrete terms: while Louisiana's Republican margins remained consistent across all five cycles never falling below eighteen points Georgia's shifted from a comfortable Republican advantage in 2008 to a razor-thin Democratic victory in 2020, reflecting the compounding effect of the permanent mobilization infrastructure documented in Chapter III.

The registration data underlying these electoral shifts confirms that Georgia's margins were not the product of demographic accident but of deliberate organizational labor. Between 2008 and 2020, white registered voters declined from 63 percent of Georgia's electorate to 53 percent — not because white voters left the state, but because the permanent infrastructure of the New Georgia Project and Fair Fight systematically activated a previously dormant majority. Black registered voters alone increased by approximately 130,000 during the 2016–2020 window, the largest numerical increase of any racial group in the state during that period, while Latino and Asian-American registration rose by roughly 60 percent and 55 percent respectively. Louisiana produced no comparable activation. Without a year-round organizing infrastructure to convert demographic presence into registered voters, and without the national party investment that followed Georgia's narrowing margins, Louisiana's electorate remained structurally frozen even as its population continued to diversify. The contrast is not between two states with different demographics it is between two states with fundamentally different relationships between their citizens and the institutions designed to represent them

5.3 Synthesis: The Long-Term Interaction of Demand and Supply

The accumulated effects of these two paths demonstrate that small structural differences can produce entirely distinct political cultures. Georgia's trajectory proves that when mobilized demand encounters a fluid institutional supply, the result is a transformative feedback loop. Louisiana's trajectory

proves that when demand is fragmented by patronage and an extractive economy, the result is a self-reinforcing loop of stasis.

Today, these compounded dynamics are visible in the modern electoral map. Georgia has emerged as a competitive swing state in presidential and senatorial contests, defined by narrow margins and a permanent, professionalized turnout infrastructure. Louisiana, by contrast, remains a reliably conservative stronghold in statewide elections, despite possessing similar racial demographics and large urban centers.

The divergence between the two states is therefore not rooted in demographic destiny alone. As this thesis has argued, it is the result of the long-term interaction between **identity formation** (the "Deep Story"), **mobilization capacity** (the engine of engagement), and **institutional supply** (the responsiveness of power structures). Understanding this divergence provides a roadmap for understanding the future of the American South: a region no longer defined by a singular political identity, but by the varied ways in which states choose to structure, or stifle, the political power of their people.

5.3.1 The Divergent Costs of Information and Participation

To understand why these two states have reached different destinations, we must synthesize the "Demand" of identity and the "Supply" of institutions through the lens of Information Costs. Bartels (2016) argues that political participation is expensive for the voter—it requires time, effort, and knowledge. In Georgia, the "Permanent Infrastructure" functions as an "Information **Subsidy." By** providing year-round education, digital engagement, and simplified registration processes, these organizations lowered the "entry fee" for the "New American Majority."

In Louisiana, the "Information Cost" remains prohibitively high. The state’s "Digital Deserts" in rural parishes, combined with the lack of a singular "Primate City" (like Atlanta) to serve as a media gravity well, means that voters are often siloed in fragmented media markets. When a state transitions to a

closed primary system (Act 1, 2024), it adds another layer of "cost" by requiring voters to navigate complex new registration rules and partisan deadlines.

This is where the synthesis of this thesis lands: Georgia's divergence is not just about having more voters; it is about having a system that lowered the price of participation. Louisiana's stasis is maintained by artificially inflating the cost of entry through restrictive laws, digital isolation, and the fortification of the primary system. Stasis, therefore, is not a lack of political energy—it is a successful institutional tax on change. By forcing the voter to work harder to be heard, Louisiana's elites successfully maintain an "Unequal Democracy" where only the most entrenched and resourced voices can afford to participate

5.4 The Feedback Loop of National Investment: Bartels and the "Supply" of Competition

A critical, yet often overlooked, factor in the divergence between Georgia and Louisiana is the role of national party investment, which Larry Bartels (2016) describes as a key component of "Institutional Supply." In *Unequal Democracy*, Bartels notes that political parties are not merely neutral observers of voter trends; they are active creators of political reality. In Georgia, the national Democratic Party saw a "fluid" institutional environment. The breakdown of the rural power structure in the Atlanta suburbs signaled to national donors and strategists that the "cost" of a vote in Georgia was lower than in other Deep South states.

This created a self-fulfilling prophecy of competition. Between 2018 and 2024, hundreds of millions of dollars in national funding poured into Georgia, providing the "supply" of television ads, professional canvassers, and data analytics. This investment lowered the information cost for voters, making the "demand" for change feel more achievable. Conversely, in Louisiana and Mississippi, the national "supply" remains restricted. Because the institutions—such as the Jungle Primary or restrictive registration laws aare perceived as "unbreakable," national parties treat these states as "extractive" rather than "competitive." They extract donations from loyal partisans but do not reinvest that capital into

statewide mobilization. This lack of investment reinforces the "Deep Story" of abandonment (Hochschild, 2016), as voters in these states see their national parties focus exclusively on "swing" neighbors like Georgia, further cementing the stasis in the Gulf South.

VI. Conclusion: Two Souths, Three Paths, and the Future of Democracy

The political divergence between Georgia and Louisiana serves as a definitive rebuttal to the theory of demographic determinism. For decades, political observers suggested that the increasing share of non-white voters across the South would inevitably lead to a region-wide partisan realignment. However, as this thesis has demonstrated, the presence of a diverse electorate is merely a prerequisite for change, not a guarantee of it. The divergent trajectories of Georgia and Louisiana reveal that political transformation is a product of the deliberate, long-term interaction between identity formation, civic mobilization, and institutional supply.

6.1 Synthesizing the Pillars of Divergence

The evidence presented in the preceding chapters illustrates that Georgia and Louisiana have moved from a shared history of the "Solid South" into two distinct political eras. This divergence was driven by three primary factors that determine whether a state can absorb demographic change or if it will remain institutionally frozen.

First, identity functions as a moral and psychological filter. Using Arlie Russell Hochschild's (2016) "deep story" framework, we see that identity in Georgia became a unified, statewide driver of competition. The rigid Black-White binary and the concentration of a new "creative class" in the Atlanta metropolitan area allowed for clear partisan signaling and a shared narrative of institutional progress. In Louisiana, however, identity remained fragmented by Catholic-Protestant splits, Creole heritage, and parish-level loyalties. This fragmentation acted as a buffer that prevented a unified statewide narrative of change from taking root, leaving the electorate siloed and susceptible to localized patronage.

Second, the engine of mobilization determines the scale of political demand. The "Stacey Abrams model" in Georgia proved that mobilization must be treated as permanent infrastructure rather than a seasonal event. By lowering the "cost of participation" (Bartels, 2016), Georgia's civic organizations converted latent demographic potential into active electoral power. In contrast, Louisiana's reliance on candidate-centered patronage machines ensured that mobilization remained episodic. Without a year-round "institutional supply" for organizing, Louisiana's Black and youth electorates remain under-activated.

Third, institutional supply determines whether mobilized demand can reach power. Larry Bartels' (2016) framework of unequal democracy finds its clearest regional expression in this comparison. In Georgia, the collapse of the County Unit System, the rise of a diversified creative economy, and the competitive pressure of a 50/50 electorate forced institutions to remain open to new coalitions. In Louisiana, the Petro-State model, the Jungle Primary, and now the closed primary transition have each served the same extractive function: insulating the existing power structure from the pressure of a changing population. Where Georgia's institutions bent, Louisiana's held. That difference — not demographics — is the axis on which this divergence turns.

6.2 The Mississippi Control Case: The Legal Moat of the Old South

To fully measure the divergence between Georgia and Louisiana, we must compare them to the "Maximum Stasis" of Mississippi. Mississippi represents a "closed loop" where demographics are effectively neutralized by the most restrictive "Institutional Supply" in the country. While Louisiana relies on a "Petro-State" economy to stabilize its politics, Mississippi utilizes a "Legal Moat."

As Bartels (2016) argues, the rules of the game—registration deadlines, the absence of no-excuse early voting, and the difficulty of restoring voting rights—are the primary ways elites control the "responsiveness" of a state. In Mississippi, these rules are designed to create a "bottleneck" that prevents the "demand" of the state's 38% Black population from ever manifesting as electoral power. Unlike

Georgia, which was forced by its creative-class economy to modernize its voting "supply," Mississippi's agrarian and extractive economy rewards political entrenchment. There is no "Primate City" in Mississippi to act as a gravity well for change. This comparison proves that demographics are not destiny. Georgia's competitive success is the result of an "Institutional Bypass," while Mississippi's stasis is the result of an "Institutional Wall."

6.2.1 The "Closed Loop" of Institutional Entrenchment

Mississippi serves as the most extreme example of what happens when "Institutional Supply" is deliberately throttled to prevent demographic shifts from altering power structures. While Louisiana has the "Petro-State" to act as a stabilizer, Mississippi utilizes a "Legal Moat." According to Bartels (2016), the rules of the game—registration deadlines, the availability of polling places, and the ease of absentee voting—are the primary ways elites control the responsiveness of the state.

In Georgia, the "supply" of voting opportunities was expanded through weeks of early voting, which allowed the "demand" of the working-class and minority electorate to manifest. In Mississippi, the lack of early voting creates a "bottleneck" that effectively preserves the power of the status quo. This is a physical manifestation of "Unequal Democracy." When combined with the lack of a major metropolitan "gravity well" like Atlanta, Mississippi remains in a state of "Pre-Realignment." By comparing the three states, we see a clear spectrum of Southern evolution: Georgia has successfully moved to a "Competitive Multi-Ethnic" model; Louisiana remains in "Fragmented Industrial Stasis"; and Mississippi remains in "Agrarian Entrenchment." This proves that demographics are not destiny; they are only as powerful as the institutions allow them to be.

6.3 Broader Implications: The "Two Souths" Thesis

The implications of this study suggest the emergence of "Two Souths." One is urbanized, economically diversified, and electorally contested—the "Sunbelt South." The other remains rural, extractive, and institutionally stagnant—the "Black Belt/Gulf South." This divergence clarifies that

Southern political evolution is not a uniform march toward progress. It is a contested process where the design of institutions determines which voices are heard.

As Hochschild (2016) argues, the "Deep Story" of the Southern voter is often one of feeling "passed over." In Georgia, the mobilization infrastructure succeeded in rewriting that story into one of agency. In Louisiana and Mississippi, the "Deep Story" remains one of abandonment. If a state's electoral rules are designed to favor elite stability, demographic shifts will continue to be muffled. Georgia's path suggests that institutional change—often forced by massive civic labor—is the only way to break the cycle of stasis.

6.4 Paths for Further Research

While this thesis focuses on these three states, the framework of Identity, Mobilization, and Power Structures offers a roadmap for future study. Researchers should look toward North Carolina and Texas, where similar growth is occurring but is being met with aggressive "Institutional Vetoes" in the form of extreme gerrymandering. Additionally, further research is needed to determine the policy consequences of this divergence. Does Georgia's institutional fluidity lead to higher state-level responsiveness to the needs of the poor compared to the petro-state stasis of Louisiana?

North Carolina presents perhaps the most urgent case for future study. Like Georgia, it possesses a large research university ecosystem, a rapidly diversifying suburban ring in the Research Triangle, and a growing Black and Latino electorate. Yet unlike Georgia, it has faced some of the most aggressive gerrymandering in the country, with court-invalidated maps repeatedly replaced by new ones designed to limit minority representation. The question North Carolina poses is whether Georgia's model of permanent civic infrastructure can survive a more hostile legal environment than the one Fair Fight navigated. Texas presents a different variant of the same problem one where Hispanic population growth complicates the clean Black-White binary that made Georgia's coalition-building so legible. Whether the

linked fate framework Dawson describes can operate across a more fragmented multiracial coalition remains an open and consequential question for the future of Southern politics.

6.5 Final Reflections

As the United States continues to polarize, state-level institutions will become the primary battlegrounds for the future of the American experiment. Georgia represents a model where the "Deep Story" of the voter and the "Institutional Supply" of the party have finally aligned, resulting in a vibrant and competitive democracy. Louisiana and Mississippi represent a warning that without a coordinated effort to build civic infrastructure and diversify the economic base, the voices of millions can remain locked behind a wall of institutional inertia. Ultimately, the divergence of these states reminds us that in politics, geography is not destiny. Power is not granted by demographics; it is built through the labor of mobilization and the reform of the institutions that hold the keys to the future. But as this thesis has argued, the most insidious form of institutional resistance is not the locked door — it is the raised price of entry. When a state inflates the cost of political participation through digital isolation, restrictive primary rules, and the absence of civic infrastructure, it does not silence its people outright. It simply makes change expensive enough that only the most entrenched voices can afford it. Georgia forced that price down. Louisiana has not. That difference, compounded over decades, is the story of the modern South.

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